

Hampton Court Palace - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

Wolsey's Palace, Henry's Prize

Hampton Court began as the most conspicuous act of self-fashioning in Tudor England. Thomas Wolsey — butcher's son from Ipswich, risen to Cardinal, Lord Chancellor, and the second most powerful man in the kingdom — began building in 1515 a palace explicitly in the new Renaissance taste, importing Italian craftsmen, with lodgings for the entire court and plumbing ahead of its time; ambassadors reported home that it outshone the king's own houses. The Venetian line about Wolsey was that one had to address him as one would the king. That magnificence became a liability the moment Wolsey failed to deliver the annulment of Henry's marriage to Catherine of Aragon. In 1528, with his position collapsing, Wolsey made a gift of Hampton Court to Henry — the political equivalent of handing over your wallet before you're mugged. It didn't save him; he died in 1530 en route to a treason trial. Henry then spent lavishly, rebuilding the Great Hall with its hammerbeam roof — the last great medieval hall built for the English crown — and installing the Chapel Royal's astonishing blue-and-gold ceiling. Five of his six wives lived here; Jane Seymour died here days after giving birth to Edward; and Henry married Catherine Parr here. Note the astronomical clock of 1540 on the inner gatehouse: pre-Copernican, with the sun dutifully circling the Earth, and showing high tide at London Bridge — the practical detail that tells you how everyone important actually arrived: by river.

The Six Wives, in These Rooms

Henry's marital saga is usually told as a national drama, but Hampton Court gives it a domestic address. Three of the six wives are woven directly into this fabric. Jane Seymour, the third, delivered the whole point of the enterprise here in October 1537: a living male heir, the future Edward the Sixth. The kingdom exhaled, the guns fired, the Te Deum was sung. And then, within two weeks, Jane was dead of the complications that killed so many Tudor mothers. She is the wife Henry mourned and, tellingly, the wife he chose to be buried beside at Windsor. Of six marriages, the one he wanted eternity with was the one that gave him a son and asked nothing else.

Katherine Howard, the fifth, supplies the palace's darkest week: arrested here in November 1541, the terrified teenager at the center of the Haunted Gallery legend, dispatched to the Tower and the block. Catherine Parr, the sixth, offers the counterweight, married to Henry here in July 1543 in a small, private ceremony in the Queen's Holyday Closet above the chapel. Learned, diplomatic, and a genuine stepmother to Henry's three children, she managed the near-impossible feat of surviving him.

Look for the marriages written into the stonework itself, because at Hampton Court, wives were an architectural problem. Above the gateway that still bears her name, Anne Boleyn's initials were entwined with Henry's, the lovers' H and A carved in triumph. When Anne fell in 1536, teams of masons were sent through the palace to erase her, chiseling out the A and substituting a J for Jane Seymour wherever they found it. They worked at speed, and they missed. A few intertwined H and A survive, high up, overlooked. It is one of the most eloquent accidents in England: a disgraced queen the king spent real money to delete, preserved by nothing more than a workman's oversight, still holding Henry's hand five

centuries after he had her killed.

Reading the Tudor Skin: Emperors, a Clock, and a Cardinal's Ego

Wolsey did not merely build large; he built fashionably, and the surfaces of Hampton Court are a coded argument about who he was. Set into the brickwork, hunt for the terracotta roundels: eight great heads of Roman emperors in baked, molded clay, commissioned by Wolsey around 1521 from an Italian sculptor, Giovanni da Maiano. This was radical. England was still building in a late-medieval Gothic idiom, and here was a churchman importing the Italian Renaissance wholesale, announcing that he was a man of the new learning, a prince of the Church who moved in Continental circles. The emperors were flattery by association: Wolsey wanted you to read imperial gravitas into a butcher's son from Ipswich. It worked well enough to make him dangerous.

Now stand under the astronomical clock in Clock Court, made in 1540 by Nicholas Oursian and very likely designed with input from Nicholas Kratzer, the German astronomer Henry kept at court. It is a magnificent pre-Copernican machine: the sun trundles obediently around a fixed Earth, because that was still the settled science. It tells the hour, the month, the day, the phase of the moon, the sign of the zodiac, and, most usefully, the time of high water at London Bridge. That last dial is the tell. It reminds us that the Thames, not the road, was the palace's front door, and that timing the tide was a practical necessity for every barge that swept up to the water gate. The clock is astronomically wrong and administratively perfect, a nice summary of the Tudor mind.

Wolsey's own badges survive here and there in the fabric, and there is a grim satisfaction in them. The man engineered every stone of this place as a monument to his indispensability, and the moment he became dispensable, Henry took it, kept it, and stamped his own initials over the top. At Hampton Court, magnificence was never neutral. It was a resume, and under Henry, a resume could become a charge sheet.

The Machinery of Magnificence: Kitchens and Court

The Tudor kitchens are the best place in Britain to grasp that a royal court was less a household than a mid-sized town in permanent motion. Henry's court numbered six hundred or more, all entitled to two hot meals a day under a strict hierarchy of fare, and Hampton Court's fifty-five kitchen rooms — boiling house, pastry house, spicery, fish court, wine cellars — were staffed by around two hundred people, nearly all men, working under military discipline. Annual provisioning ran to over a thousand oxen, eight thousand sheep, and staggering quantities of ale and wine; ale was the default drink at every age because water was rightly distrusted. The great open hearths consumed more than a tonne of oak a day, and being a spit-turner was a formal, sweating occupation. The economics were the point: feeding hundreds conspicuously well was how a Renaissance monarch demonstrated power, and dining was theatre — the Great Watching Chamber's name is literal. Two details worth catching: the “coffins,” thick standing pastry cases used as baking vessels rather than food; and the replica wine fountain in Base Court, based on one shown in a period painting of Henry's diplomatic summit at the Field of the Cloth of Gold, which on festival days at that summit reportedly ran with red wine. Costumed historic cookery still happens over live fire on selected days — worth asking at the desk immediately on arrival.

The Chocolate Kitchen and the Court's Long Afterlife of Appetite

The Tudor kitchens are the famous ones, but tucked away near the Georgian rooms is a smaller, stranger survival, and it is worth seeking out: the royal Chocolate Kitchen, rediscovered by curators and opened to the public only in recent years. It is the sole surviving royal chocolate kitchen in Britain, a little suite of rooms with its original stove, where hot chocolate, then a luxurious and faintly medicinal novelty, was prepared for the early Georgian kings, George the First and George the Second.

Chocolate arrived in Europe from the Americas as a bitter, ground paste, and by the early eighteenth century it had become the fashionable elite breakfast, a status drink taken thick, spiced, and sweetened. Preparing it was skilled, secretive work, and the royal chocolatier was a person of real standing. Hampton Court's was a man named Thomas Tosier, whose wife, by contemporary accounts, cheerfully traded on his intimate access to the king. It is the same court logic you meet everywhere in this palace: proximity to the royal body, even via his breakfast cup, was a form of power worth advertising.

The Chocolate Kitchen is a useful reminder that Hampton Court did not stop cooking when the Tudors left. The great machine of provisioning simply changed its menu and its masters. Where Henry's court had performed magnificence through mountains of roasted meat and towers of spun sugar, the Georgians performed it through the exotic new luxuries of a global trading empire: chocolate, coffee, tea, and sugar arriving from colonies and plantations across the Atlantic. The kitchens track the changing sources of royal display across two centuries, from the home counties supplying Henry's oxen to a transatlantic economy delivering the beans for a king's morning cup. Ask at the desk whether the Chocolate Kitchen is staffed on the day you visit; when it is, they sometimes grind and prepare chocolate the eighteenth-century way, and the smell alone is worth the detour.

William, Mary and Wren: The Unfinished Versailles

The palace's split personality is the residue of an abandoned masterplan. When William the Third and Mary the Second took the throne in 1689, they found the Tudor palace hopelessly unfashionable — the standard was now Louis the Fourteenth's Versailles — and commissioned Christopher Wren to demolish and replace the whole thing. Money and Mary's death in 1694 intervened; Wren rebuilt only the king's and queen's apartments around Fountain Court, and the project stopped, leaving Tudor brick fused to English baroque along a visible seam. Walk from Clock Court into Fountain Court and you cross a century and a half of architectural ideology in ten steps. The State Apartments beyond are a study in monarchy as choreography — the sequence of guard chamber, presence chamber, privy chamber filtering visitors by rank as they approached the king — with the King's Staircase painted by Verrio as flamboyant Williamite propaganda. William's story ends here with an equine footnote: he died in 1702 after his horse stumbled on a molehill in the park at Hampton Court, and Jacobites toasted “the little gentleman in black velvet” for years after. The gardens hold the era's other superlatives: the Great Vine, planted 1768 under Capability Brown's tenure as gardener here, still producing hundreds of kilos of grapes as possibly the world's largest vine; and the maze of around 1700, Britain's oldest surviving hedge maze.

The Gardens as Statecraft: Restoring a King's View

Most visitors treat the gardens as a pleasant afterthought to the buildings. They are, in fact, one of the most important formal landscapes in Britain, and the Privy Garden in particular is a landmark of a different kind: a scholarly resurrection. When William the Third rebuilt the southern range, he laid out beneath his new apartments a private baroque garden in the Franco-Dutch manner, completed in 1702, all crisp geometry, clipped scrollwork of dwarf box, gravel, and carefully placed statuary, designed to be read as a composition from the King's rooms above. It was a political landscape as much as a horticultural one, a Protestant answer to Louis the Fourteenth's Versailles, order and control expressed in living plants.

Over the following centuries it was softened, overgrown, and lost, buried under Victorian shrubberies and mature trees. Then, in the 1990s, Historic Royal Palaces did something bold: they stripped it all back and reconstructed the garden precisely as it had been in 1702, using surviving plans, planting lists, and archaeology of the original paths and beds. Trees that had stood for generations were felled to recover a view that had not existed for two hundred years. It was controversial and it was right, and the result is the finest reconstructed baroque garden in the country. Stand where William stood and you see, more or less, what he saw.

Look outward, too, at the vast Great Fountain Garden with its avenues of yew radiating away from the palace in a goose-foot pattern, and at the long straight canal, the Long Water, driving the eye to the horizon. This is landscape as absolutism, nature marshaled into lines that all point back to the sovereign. Even the maze, planted for William around 1700 and designed by the royal gardeners George London and Henry Wise, belongs to this world of controlled, geometric pleasure. The whole southern half of Hampton Court, buildings and gardens together, is a single argument about power, made in brick, water, gravel, and clipped hedge.

The Great Vine and the Oldest Tennis Court

Two of the grounds' quieter superlatives reward a detour. The first is the Great Vine, and the numbers are genuinely astonishing. It was planted in 1768, during the tenure of Lancelot “Capability” Brown as the king's gardener here, grown from a cutting taken at Valentines Mansion in Essex. From that single cutting has grown what Guinness World Records recognizes as the largest grapevine on Earth: a stem now

around four meters in girth at the base, with its longest rod trained to more than thirty-six meters under glass. It still crops heavily every year, averaging something like two hundred and seventy kilograms of Black Hamburg dessert grapes, which the palace sells to visitors each September. Queen Victoria had its grapes sent to the royal table. A single plant, more than two and a half centuries old, still fruiting, tended by a full-time vine keeper who looks after essentially nothing else. It is one of the most extraordinary living objects in Britain, and it sits in a modest glasshouse most people walk straight past.

The second is the Royal Tennis Court, home to real tennis, the intricate medieval ancestor of the lawn game, played indoors off sloping penthouse roofs and into hazard openings, with heavy handmade balls and asymmetrical racquets. Henry the Eighth was an addict and, in his athletic youth, a formidable player; Wolsey's original court stood here, and fragments of his walls survive. The court you can look into today was built for Charles the First in 1625, and remarkably it is still in constant use, the oldest real tennis court in Britain where the game is actively played. If a match is on, pause and watch a few points. The scoring is baffling, the angles are geometry made physical, and you are watching a sport played more or less unchanged since the Tudor kings sweated on this very spot.

Ghost Stories as Compressed History

Hampton Court markets itself as Britain's most haunted palace, and the ghost stories are worth taking seriously — not as evidence of the supernatural, but as the palace's traumatic history retold in folk form. The Haunted Gallery legend concerns Catherine Howard, Henry's fifth queen, arrested here in November 1541 at around nineteen for adultery amounting to treason; the tale of her breaking from her guards to run screaming toward the chapel where Henry heard Mass is unverifiable but plausible in its geography, and staff and visitors have reported distress at a consistent spot for well over a century — a psychologist studying it found measurable cold drafts and suggestible expectations doing most of the work, which is its own interesting result. Jane Seymour, who died here in 1537 after producing the male heir, supplies the palace's white lady. And the modern classic is "Skeletor," the 2003 CCTV footage of fire doors flying open and a robed figure closing them — released by the palace, never explained, and a masterclass in institutional mischief. What the stories encode is real enough: this building witnessed the deaths, arrests and griefs of the Tudor state at close range. The warders, who give superb value on this topic, tend to answer the ghost question with a practiced "I only tell people what I've seen" — enjoy them.

The Manufacture of a Haunted Palace

It is worth asking a historian's question about the ghosts: not are they real, but how did Hampton Court become "the most haunted palace in Britain" in the first place? Reputations like this are made, and this one has a fairly traceable history. For much of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, after the court stopped living here, the palace filled with grace-and-favour residents, impoverished aristocrats and widows of servants of the Crown, granted apartments in the old royal lodgings. These were exactly the conditions in which ghost lore flourishes: a vast, half-empty, decaying building of drafts and creaks, occupied by elderly people with long memories, sharp social rivalries, and time on their hands. Servants' gossip and genteel boredom are excellent conductors of the supernatural.

The stories were then codified. In the late nineteenth century the antiquarian Ernest Law wrote the great scholarly history of the palace, and in gathering its legends he helped fix them in print, lending the ghosts an air of documented pedigree. Take the "Grey Lady," Sybil Penn, nurse to the young Edward the Sixth and a servant to Elizabeth, who died of smallpox in 1562. The apparition reports attached to her cluster suspiciously around 1829, the year her tomb was disturbed when the local church was rebuilt, and they gained a perfect folkloric detail when staff reported a strange whirring behind a palace wall that, opened up, revealed a forgotten chamber containing an old spinning wheel. Sybil, of course, had been a noted spinner. It is a beautifully shaped story, and its shape is the point: it has the neat, satisfying closure that real events rarely provide and legends always do.

None of this makes the palace's grief less real. Catherine Howard's terror, Jane Seymour's death in childbed, the executions and disgraces, all genuinely happened within these walls. What the ghost tradition does is give that trauma a durable, repeatable form, a way for each generation to feel the past physically. Hampton Court is not haunted by the dead so much as by its own history, endlessly retold, and the palace, wisely, leans into it.

Woven Gold: The Art You Might Walk Past

The easiest treasures to miss at Hampton Court are hanging on the walls of the Great Hall: Henry the Eighth's tapestry set, *The Story of Abraham*, woven in Brussels in the 1540s with wool, silk, and actual gilt-metal-wrapped thread. Tapestry, not painting, was the supreme art form of the Tudor court — a single set like this cost as much as a warship, and inventories valued Henry's tapestry collection above almost everything else he owned. Five centuries of light and coal smoke have dimmed them to sepia, but conservation imaging shows the originals blazed with gold and color; on sunny days you can still catch metallic glints in the weave. The palace also anchors the Royal Collection's most important Renaissance possession outside the paintings galleries: Mantegna's *Triumphs of Caesar*, nine monumental canvases from the 1480s bought by Charles the First, so prized that even Cromwell — busy selling off the executed king's art collection — insisted they be kept. Charles the First is the palace's other shadow: he was held prisoner here in 1647 and escaped through the gardens, briefly, before his eventual trial. If the group's energy allows one adult detour while kids do the Magic Garden, the Cumberland Art Gallery's rotating Royal Collection pictures — Holbein, Rembrandt, Van Dyck have all hung there — is a quiet ten minutes exceptionally well spent.

Mantegna's *Triumphs of Caesar*: The Renaissance in a Side Gallery

If you make one deliberate detour beyond the crowd-pulling state rooms, make it to the Mantegna Gallery, because it holds what is arguably the greatest set of Italian Renaissance paintings in Britain and one of the most important anywhere outside Italy. The *Triumphs of Caesar* is a sequence of nine large canvases painted by Andrea Mantegna between roughly 1484 and 1492 for the Gonzaga rulers of Mantua. Read left to right, they form a single continuous procession: Julius Caesar's triumphal parade through Rome, the captured spoils and standards, the trumpeters and elephants, the trophies and captives, culminating in Caesar himself. Mantegna, obsessed with the physical remains of antiquity, reconstructed the ancient world with an archaeologist's rigor, and the result is less a painting than a scholarly resurrection of Rome, monumental and cool and strange.

The story of how they came to hang beside the Thames is itself a lesson in the movement of European power and money. In 1629 Charles the First, the most ambitious royal collector England has ever produced, bought the bankrupt Gonzaga family's entire art collection, one of the coups of seventeenth-century connoisseurship, and the *Triumphs* were its supreme prize. Then, after Charles lost his head, comes the twist that keeps them here: when the victorious Commonwealth sold off the dead king's staggering collection to the crowned heads of Europe, Oliver Cromwell personally held the *Triumphs of Caesar* back from the sale. A republican Lord Protector had obvious reasons to enjoy a picture of a conqueror's spoils, and so, by a quirk of regicidal taste, nine of the finest canvases of the Italian Renaissance stayed in England.

They are fragile, painted thinly in glue-based distemper rather than robust oil, and centuries of clumsy old restoration once nearly obscured them; modern conservation has recovered much of Mantegna's original chill and precision. Give them ten unhurried minutes. In a palace that overwhelms with Tudor brick and baroque swagger, this quiet room holds the deepest art of all.

Charles the First's Two Hampton Courts: Collector and Captive

Charles the First haunts Hampton Court more persistently than any ghost, because the palace held him in both of his historical roles: as the greatest connoisseur ever to sit on the English throne, and as a prisoner on the road to the scaffold. It was Charles who filled these rooms with the art you have been

admiring. His agents scoured Europe, and his purchase of the Gonzaga collection in 1629 brought the Mantegna canvases here; under him the royal holdings became one of the supreme collections in the world, a gathering of Titian, Raphael, Correggio, and Van Dyck that a king assembled while his political capital drained away. There is a case to be made that Charles understood pictures far better than he understood Parliaments.

The reckoning came in the civil wars. Defeated, Charles was brought to Hampton Court in August 1647, held under a genteel form of house arrest by the victorious army, permitted his household and his walks in the gardens while his captors and Parliament argued over what to do with a king they had beaten but not yet dared to remove. On the night of the eleventh of November 1647 he slipped his guards and fled through the grounds toward the coast, a gamble that ended not in freedom but at Carisbrooke Castle on the Isle of Wight, and from there, by degrees, to his trial and his execution outside the Banqueting House in January 1649. He walked these gardens as a captive knowing, one imagines, exactly how thin his options had become.

His death then rebounded on the very collection he had built. The Commonwealth ordered the king's magnificent pictures inventoried and sold to pay the state's debts, scattering Stuart masterpieces across the courts of Europe, where the Prado and the Louvre still glitter with them. At the Restoration a committee clawed back what it could, but only a fraction returned. So the art at Hampton Court is doubly Charles's: what he gathered, and what survived the catastrophe of gathering it. The connoisseur and the captive were the same man, in the same palace, a decade apart.